

Q2) 'Climate change is a hot topic that we give a cold shoulder to.' To what extent is this true?

Strengths	Weaknesses
Many responses were familiar with the topic and grasped the focus of the question. Most responses were able to support their points with appropriate examples. Stronger responses had a wider range of illustrations which were analysed in greater detail to advance the arguments presented. Introductions generally succeeded in establishing why climate change is a hot topic and proceeded to address the world's response to climate change.	Weaker responses tended to list the examples or adopted a more descriptive approach at the expense of analysis and evaluation. Examples were not always aligned with the topic sentences. Very weak responses had either outdated examples or examples which are factually inaccurate. Eg: China did not ratify the Paris Agreement. In very weak responses, links were awkward, at times mechanical. The opening line in each paragraph is often a repetition of the question with little variation in expression. Weaker responses strayed to focus on the severity of climate change and our obligations instead of addressing the question - analysing the degree to which attention and efforts have been paid by the world to climate change. Paired approach tended to be example-driven and were limited in their scope. Their arguments centred largely on the overgeneralisation in the question and their rebuttals focused on providing examples to show exception.

Key Terms

"climate change"

-Changes that have been globally observed to have occurred in earth's climate. These changes have been attributed directly or indirectly to human activity, and is in addition to natural climate variability observed over comparable time periods in earth's history. The key indicators of climate change fall into the broad categories of, or are related to, *Greenhouse Gases, Weather and Climate, Oceans, Snow and Ice, Health and Society, and Ecosystems* (<https://www.epa.gov/climate-indicators>).

"hot topic" *

-a subject that is being talked about at various levels, amongst the masses, in the media, and even governments. There is also an implication that it is especially one that causes a lot of disagreement, and is controversial.

"We"

-It can refer to individuals, community, and governments, and that should be reflected in the arguments.

“give a cold shoulder to”

-It means to deliberately disregard something or someone in an unfriendly way, and in the context of this question, if climate change is being given a cold shoulder to, candidates are to argue the extent to which climate change is being given enough attention by the world.

“To what extent is this true”

-A good response must be able to quantify and qualify the degree to which attention and efforts have been paid by the world to climate change.

Recommended Stand

It is largely **true**. Despite climate change being pointed to as one major issue the world has to deal with, its impacts and implications have not been taken seriously, such that no real concrete action has been taken to deal with it.

Note: The idea of climate change being a “hot topic” is a given, a known or established fact or situation that should be mentioned at least once in the introduction but which does not warrant a lengthy explanation/description in the content paragraphs themselves.

Why climate change is a hot topic today

Climate change is the defining issue of our time. From shifting weather patterns that threaten food production, to rising sea levels that increase the risk of catastrophic flooding, the impacts of climate change are global in scope and unprecedented in scale. Science has proven that humans are the cause of it, despite controversial pushbacks from various groups, and we are currently at a dangerous ‘tipping point’ where we face disastrous and irreversible changes to our climate system if drastic action is not taken soon.

Global protests by youth, record weather extremes and a series of groundbreaking scientific and media reports have also helped to increase awareness of the problem of climate change, and the need to redirect our technology, science, finance and ingenuity to transform our economies and promote a sustainable future for all.

Suggested Approach

Part A. Acknowledge that individuals, communities and states have put in, and are putting in a certain amount of efforts to deal with climate change, in accordance with scientists’ research findings and discussion outcomes of global stakeholders.

Part B. Argue that all the global and community progress in dealing with climate change is illusory, with many individuals and key communities not heeding the calls for action (“*give a cold shoulder to*”) to be carried out, and with many governments and business corporations not adhering by any form of controls on their earth damaging activities due to various reasons.

Possible Arguments

Part A. Acknowledge that individuals, communities and states have put in, and are putting in a certain amount of efforts to deal with climate change, in accordance with scientists' research findings and discussion outcomes of global stakeholders.

1. A more cooperative world has seen it become more concerted and rigorous in combating climate change, after many years of hits and misses, and false starts in this area.

This is evident in the pledges made by both nations and companies in enhancing their ambition or action of their NDCs (Nationally Determined Contributions) after COP25 (Conference of the Parties 25), the annual United Nations meeting to discuss international action on climate change in Madrid, Spain in 2019. 33 countries (including the European Union) have stated their intention to update an NDC by 2020, while 133 countries have stated their intention to enhance ambition or action in an NDC by 2020. In addition, some non-state actors at the COP, for example, 177 companies, have pledged to cut emissions in line with the 1.5C target as part of the Climate Ambition Alliance.

With many countries ramping up their climate efforts, from setting bolder emission-reduction targets and protecting forests to phasing out coal-fired power plants, we must not disregard the significance of such efforts despite the Trump's Administration's ongoing hostility toward climate action and Russia's failure to ratify the Paris Agreement. This is because China and India, the world's largest carbon emitters, have also made pledges to combat climate change, with China pledging to strive for carbon neutrality by 2060 and India emerging as a global leader in renewable energy.

<https://www.newscientist.com/article/2225171-what-is-the-uns-cop25-climate-summit-and-why-does-it-matter/>

2. Many communities are already suffering the repercussions of climate change, so that people are paying much more attention to the discussions carried out by the global political leaders and other stakeholders.

They are carrying out public petitioning and even protest movements to force governments to deal with climate change more effectively. Hurricanes, wildfires and floods caused directly by climate change have taken many lives and caused havoc in many communities. Members of affected communities have taken to the media, as well as the streets to get their voices heard, sometimes in violent ways. Those outside of these communities have also lent their voices, in the name of humanity, and compassion.

Example: Striking students have joined Valentine's Day rallies across the world as the protest movement attempts to ratchet up pressure on governments and companies on the first anniversary of nationwide climate strikes in the UK in 2020. The growth of the protest movement has been rapid as students are now backed by longer established environmental organisations, such as Global Justice Now, Greenpeace and the Green party, and even included a trade union climate bloc.

<https://edition.cnn.com/2020/01/08/business/munich-re-climate-change-natural-disasters/index.html>

<https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2020/feb/14/school-climate-strikers-join-valentines-day-protests-across-world>

<https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2020/feb/15/extinction-rebellion-protest-at-gatwick-and-london-fashion-week>

Part B. Argue that all the global and community progress in dealing with climate change is illusory, with many individuals and key communities still actually not heeding the calls for action (“give a cold shoulder to”) to be carried out, and with many governments and business corporations not implementing any forms of control on their earth-damaging activities, due to various reasons.

1. Objective and accurate understanding of the causes and impacts of, and possible solutions amongst the majority of the public is still quite lacking. Hence, many do not want to or know how to deal with the problem of climate change effectively.

One would think that after decades of the world dealing with climate change, an accurate and convincing picture of the dire climate changes that humankind faces would emerge out of the climate scientists, the policy makers, and the media, the people supposedly at the forefront of the fight. But, upon closer scrutiny of the way climate change has been communicated to the public, it is not quite the case. Too often, accounts of the damage exacted by climate change is lost in environmental jargon, and, or there is a tendency to either understate or to overstate the situation. Worse still, much of the scientific community’s sharing about climate change and what must be done to deal with it give conflicting explanation. This has the outcome of many choosing to ignore the problems altogether.

Example: The New York Times makes a concerted effort to drive home the point that climate change is real, but it does a poor job of presenting the basic facts about climate change that could convince sceptics. This is evident in a large percentage of the American public not knowing global warming is already happening, that it is caused by record levels of carbon dioxide from fossil fuel burning, that 99% of climate scientists agree on this and that the changes are effectively permanent.

Readings:

<https://www.bbc.com/news/magazine-34858199>

<https://news.berkeley.edu/2019/09/19/in-media-coverage-of-climate-change-where-are-the-facts/>

<https://www.bbc.com/news/science-environment-49689018>

2. In some of the most important countries, discussions associated with climate change and its impacts, rather than becoming a call for concrete action for governments and the masses, have become merely issues that pit one political faction against another, with many turning a blind eye to what needs to be done at the ground level.

This has most apparently happened in one of the largest contributor to global climate change, the United States of America, where politics seemed to have got in the way of the facts, and where genuine and accurate climate science have been distorted and manipulated for political support. This has the outcome of turning climate change into a non-issue in the eyes of the public, and tragically disregarding the evidence placed before all.

Example: Climate change quickly emerged as one of the fault lines in the Trump Administration. Donald Trump was caught in the power struggle between Jared Kushner, his son-in-law, and Steve Bannon, representative of the “alternative right”, who finally persuaded Trump to make good on his promise to withdraw the US from the Paris climate accord.

Readings:

<https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2017/jul/07/climate-change-denial-scepticism-cynicism-politics>

<https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2020/feb/14/school-climate-strikers-join-valentines-day-protests-across-world>

<https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2019/apr/08/trump-administration-sabotages-major-conservation-effort-defying-congress>

3. Politicians are still giving climate change a cold shoulder as they prioritise economic interests over environmental conservation.

Discussions at the highest level globally, right up to the level of the United Nations Climate Summit, and stretching all the way back to the 1992 Kyoto Protocol, have not exactly facilitated a clear and coherent global response to climate change. Reasons for this occurrence include economic imperatives on the part of many still developing nations, as well as differences in political ideology amongst nations. The more recent agreements are also, and still not binding in many ways.

Example: The destruction of the Amazon rainforest in Brazil has increased rapidly since President Bolsonaro took over and his government scaled back efforts to fight illegal logging, ranching and mining. Mr Bolsonaro has declared that Brazil's vast protected lands were an obstacle to economic growth and promised to open them up to commercial exploitation.

<https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2019/dec/21/un-climate-talks-deadlock-cop25>

<https://worldmapper.org/unchanging-politics-of-climate-change/>